



Ready Research **What works to promote charitable donations: A meta-review with meta-meta-analysis**

The review in brief

We investigated what works (and what doesn't work) to increase charitable donation behaviour by collating the highest quality existing published research. We found that charities could increase donations by (1) helping donors feel confident in their donation, (2) providing donors with a meaningful explanation for why their donation is needed, (3) helping donors look good in front of others, and (4) seeking and advertise tax deductibility.

Why did we do this review?

If we can convince people to donate more, and donate more effectively, we can better promote flourishing & reduce suffering. A lot of work done by charities to encourage donations is based on intuitions or sometimes research from marketing. But just as some charities are significantly more effective than others, we believe that some interventions to promote charitable donations could be significantly more effective than others. In this review, we try to identify and recommend those effective interventions.

What did we do in this review?

This review of systematic reviews ("meta-review") examined which interventions increase the size or likelihood of charitable donations (the altruistic transfer of money from a person to an organisation that helps people in need). We also tried to estimate the size of the impact of different interventions on donation behaviour by combining other estimates reported in previous research ("meta-meta-analysis").

What research did we find?

We synthesised evidence from 21 systematic reviews, some of which included meta-analyses. These reviews represent 1,339 individual studies and more than 2 million people and were published before March 2021. We found 13 different types of interventions to promote charitable giving. Some examined the donation size, and others examined donation likelihood (e.g., to donate vs. not donate at all).

Across all studies and interventions, the average effect size was $r=0.08$, 95% CI [0.03, 0.12], $K=23$. This means that **choosing an intervention at random** out of those we catalogued, you would expect an increase in donation size or likelihood for **1 out of every 21 people**¹. Some interventions were much more effective than others. The best interventions increased donation size or likelihood for between **1 in 7 people** and **1 in 12 people**.

Where to get further information?

[Read the peer-reviewed paper for free](#) at Voluntas: International Journal of Voluntary & Nonprofit Organisations:

Saeri, A. K., Slattery, P., Lee, J., Houlden, T., Farr, N., Gelber, R. L., Stone, J., Huuskes, L., Timmons, S., Windle, K., Spajic, L., Freeman, L., Moss, D., Behar, J., Schubert, S., Grundy, E. A. C., Zorker, M. (2022). What Works to Increase Charitable Donations? A Meta-Review with Meta-Meta-Analysis. *Voluntas: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations*. doi: [10.1007/s11266-022-00499-y](https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-022-00499-y)

What is Ready Research?

Ready Research coordinates and conducts behaviour science research to improve decision-making and behaviour for the world's most pressing problems. In this project, we recruited and trained interested volunteers in research methods and writing, and convened an advisory group of charity experts and practitioners who provided advice on the research protocol and where & how to communicate the findings. You can visit our website, readyresearch.org; email the project lead, [Michael Noetel](mailto:Michael.Noetel@readyresearch.org); or email the primary author of the peer-reviewed paper, [Alexander Saeri](mailto:Alexander.Saeri@readyresearch.org).

¹ This and other '1 in N' statements represent the *Number Needed to Treat* (NNT) based on the effect size, a statistic commonly used in medicine and clinical research. Read an [introduction to NNT](#), or [Furukawa & Leucht \(2011\)](#) for a technical explanation of how we calculated NNT from Cohen's *d*. We used a Control Event Rate (CER) of 20%.



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Recommendations for charities and practitioners

What worked

Recommendation	Examples of strategies that worked	Increased donation size / likelihood
<i>Help donors feel confident in their donation</i>	Showing prospective donors that others have donated money	1 in 7 people
	Describing a single, identifiable beneficiary	1 in 12 people
<i>Provide donors with a meaningful explanation for why their donation is needed</i>	Clearly describing the need of the beneficiaries	1 in 12 people
	Responsibly using tactics to start a conversation about the donation need, such as by asking for a strange (17c) or very small (1c) amount of money	1 in 6 people
<i>Help donors look good in front of others</i>	Soliciting or reporting on donations in a public setting (while avoiding guilt or social pressure) Sharing the donor identity and donation size with beneficiaries Emphasising personal pride and self-efficacy through transparency of reporting and to establish a positive social norm of giving	1 in 11 people
<i>Seek and advertise tax deductibility</i>	Registering for tax-deductibility status as a charity Communicating the positive consequences of tax-deductibility on donation size	Tax deduction of \$1 led to additional \$1.44 in donations

What didn't work

Recommendation	What we found
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<i>Donation matching</i>	- Offering matching for individual donations did not increase donation behaviour (Engel 2011) - Some recent work suggests that making the link between donation behaviour and a 'threshold' match may be effective (e.g., if individual donations together reach \$10,000, the amount will be matched; Gee & Shreck 2018)
<i>Asking for a large donation first, then asking for a smaller amount after refusal</i>	The 'door in the face' technique (aka 'request than retreat') did not increase donation behaviour (Feeley 2012)
<i>Using artificial cues (e.g., pictures of eyes)</i>	The use of artificial surveillance cues, such as placing a picture of eyes above a donation jar, does not increase donation behaviour (Northover 2017)
<i>Encouraging snap judgements</i>	Forcing intuitive (rather than deliberative) thinking did not increase donation behaviour (Fromell 2020)



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Recommendations for researchers and funders

Recommendation	How to do it / considerations
<i>Systematically review topics of practical relevance</i>	- Identify assumptions of charity marketing (e.g., "efficacy is more important than overhead", "videos generate more emotion than text") and conduct a systematic review on this topic. - If doing so, consider assessing the quality of the literature (e.g., AMSTAR2 checklist) and follow the PRISMA statement when reporting results. None of our included reviews followed best-practice recommendations.
<i>Publish randomised field trials (e.g., A/B tests) that examine real behaviour and easily translatable research</i>	- Test interventions during existing charitable behaviour opportunities (e.g., tip jar, fundraising events, corporate philanthropy) - Using meaningful amounts of money in laboratory experiments Get in contact with us if you'd like to collaborate on a field trial with your charity
<i>Assess determinants of effective giving (e.g. giving to highly effective charities)</i>	Conduct a systematic review of experimental and other primary research investigating effective donation behaviour specifically

Responses to feedback on this document

Feedback / comment	Our response
How did you synthesise the	Peter Slattery (May 2021)



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literature in this review?	Read our full paper for details, especially Supplementary File 1 where we discuss how we assessed the quality of the evidence and our certainty in the results of each included review
How might these findings be applied to encourage giving to more effective charities, rather than just all charities	Peter Slattery (May 2021) People tend to give more when they link it to a personal goal. If the audience seeks to be effective, or cares about certainty, or impact or research, you can suggest that giving effectively would be more enjoyable than giving ineffectively. Here's an article on a related topic

Social media summary content



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WHAT WORKS TO PROMOTE CHARITABLE DONATIONS?

We investigated what works (and what doesn't work) to increase charitable donation behaviour by reviewing the published research.

This is a summary of what worked, and some examples:



Help donors feel confident in their donation

- Show prospective donors that others have donated money
- Describe a single, identifiable beneficiary



Provide donors with a meaningful explanation

- Clearly describe the need of the beneficiaries
- Ask for an unusual amount of money to prompt a conversation and explanation of need



Help donors look good in front of others

- Solicit or report on donations in a public setting
- Share the donor identity and donation size with beneficiaries



Seek and advertise tax-deductibility

- Register for tax-deductibility status as a charity
- Communicate the positive consequences of tax deductibility on donation size

For more information, see: Saeri, A.K., Slattery, P., Lee, J. et al. What Works to Increase Charitable Donations? A Meta-Review with Meta-Meta-Analysis. *Voluntas* (2022). <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-022-00499-y>



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